

Wise, and Far From Me

On Wisdom in the Book of Ecclesiastes

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A. Introduction

The book of Ecclesiastes (Kohelet) is known for the many internal contradictions that surface within it. Our Sages were already aware of this problem, and some even wished to suppress the book^[1] because of the general confusion it gives the reader, at least on a simple reading. This problem — the apparent inconsistency of the book's author — carries real weight, since it prevents us from drawing any single, unambiguous conclusion or understanding on the book's various subjects; on a great many of them, the book's statements stand in direct contradiction to one another — whether this is the question of the justice of divine judgment in the world, the attitude toward woman, the attitude toward joy, the attitude toward labor, and more.

Among these recurring subjects, one that is especially hard for us to form a consistent key of interpretation toward is wisdom. Kohelet describes his experience of wisdom, and his conclusions about it, in various and contradictory verses throughout the book:

"...for in much wisdom is much vexation, and he that increases knowledge increases sorrow." (1:18)

"Then I saw that wisdom excels folly, as light excels darkness. The wise man's eyes are in his head, but the fool walks in darkness; and yet I perceived that one event happens to them all. Then I said in my heart, 'As it happens to the fool, so it will happen even to me; and why was I then more wise?' Then I said in my heart that this also was vanity. For there is no remembrance of the wise more than of the fool for ever, seeing that in the days to come all will have been long forgotten. And how does the wise man die, just like the fool!" (2:13–16)

"For to the man who is good in His sight He gives wisdom, and knowledge, and joy." (2:26)

"For wisdom is a defense, and money is a defense; but the excellency of knowledge is that wisdom gives life to those who have it." (7:12)

"Who is like the wise man? And who knows the interpretation of a thing? A man's wisdom makes his face shine, and the boldness of his face is changed." (8:1)

"When I applied my heart to know wisdom, and to see the business that is done upon the earth (for also there is that neither day nor night sees sleep with his eyes), then I saw all the work of God, that man cannot find out the work that is done under the sun; because

however much a man labors to seek it out, yet he shall not find it; yes further, though a wise man think to know it, yet shall he not be able to find it." (8:16–17)

"...and I said, wisdom is better than strength... wisdom is better than weapons of war..." (9:16–18)

We see the contradictions and the confusion clearly. A multitude of varied attitudes and diverse outlooks on the value of wisdom arise here, which it is hard to see how they can be simply reconciled with one another.

In this essay we will walk the paths of the book of Ecclesiastes, with our central occupation being the question of wisdom. We will try to survey, order and understand the various attitudes toward wisdom, and to construct the relationship among them. In the course of this engagement we will also come to discuss what I see as the book's foundational issues in general, which shed light also on the specific subject of wisdom — such as the book's style, its existential character, the subject of hevel (vanity), joy, and the like. Likewise, over the course of the journey, we will permit ourselves at times to pause our engagement with the book and its inner ideas and to engage instead in translating its insights into our own modern, faith-based language. Finally, we will summarize what we have raised regarding the complex relation to wisdom. At the end of the essay a closing chapter is added, dealing with the possible contribution of the book of Ecclesiastes to the faith-based confrontation with the new mindset called "postmodernism."

B. The Starting Point

After the opening passage (1:2–11), headed "Vanity of vanities, all is vanity," in which the book's key question is presented — "What profit has man of all his labor which he takes under the sun?" — Kohelet explains: "I, Kohelet, was king over Israel in Jerusalem; and I applied my heart to seek and to search out by wisdom concerning all that is done under heaven" (1:12–13). That is: after presenting the problem, King Solomon opens with an attempt "to search out by wisdom" for some kind of philosophical solution that will grant relief to his distress. He turns to wisdom, knowledge and learning as a remedy, a solution, or an aid for coping with life's problems, out of a belief that they truly contain what is needed. From this we learn that, at least at the start of his path, Kohelet was optimistic about the role of wisdom; he saw it as something positive and meaningful, and thought it capable of granting a solution to man's distress. This believing attitude toward wisdom is the starting point of the book.

From here we come to argue that Kohelet's discussion of wisdom is relevant to our own world. Our spiritual and cultural world still rests, to a great degree, on the foundational assumptions instilled deep within Western-human culture by the movement of the Enlightenment, at whose center stands the central importance of reason for solving the problems of existence (although this conclusion already existed, in a somewhat different form, in Aristotelian and medieval philosophy, and is prominent among early authorities such as the Rambam and Rav Saadia Gaon). There is an assumption, at times hidden and at times overt, lodged in our world without it ever occurring to us to doubt it, that the addition

of knowledge, learning, the broadening of understanding, the asking of questions, inquiry and the search for wisdom, are positive in their basic essence.

Since we encounter a broad gap between our own spiritual world and that of Kohelet (on many subjects), the necessary result is a neutralizing of the influence of studying the book on our own world. It is important to understand, therefore, that on this particular matter our starting points are identical, and that this is not a gap built in from the outset; and hence, that Kohelet's complex attitude, which is the result of the piercing process of inquiry and thought he undergoes over the course of the book, can constitute a highly relevant and significant source of nourishment for us.

C. What Kind of Wisdom?

In order to understand Kohelet's full attitude toward wisdom, we must first understand what he was seeking within it, and what kind of questions he wanted it to answer. For this purpose, let us first raise the question of what the distress is that he describes.

The distress, as presented in the opening and further on, is the feeling that the whole of reality and life in the world are devoid of meaning.[2] This conclusion arrives from a supra-historical observation, according to which man's deeds neither add nor subtract on any true scale, and that, by the law of nature, everything returns to itself and nothing changes. A deterministic note arises, producing a deep sense that deeds and life within the framework of the world, aimed at changing things within it and building structures within it, have no meaning whatsoever, since the goal is hopeless, or, at the very least, things are destined to return to their former state and the structures will not stand. Even if you act within reality, you are temporary, and after your time, all your undertakings may well dissolve and be destroyed.[3] Your life retroactively becomes meaningless. This is the primary problem, out of which many further tormenting questions arise.

As noted, this distress naturally arouses in Kohelet the attempt to search out, by wisdom, a philosophical solution that will restore the meaning of existence (1:13). However, we see from the account that follows that the plane of his search is not theological or spiritual-ideational thought. The wisdom he seeks is existentialist thought, and the domain in which he searches is the domain of experience and lived trial. He tries out various styles of ways of existing that might offer relief for the problem — not for the philosophical paradox and vanity, but for the sense of existential emptiness that flows from this outlook. The standard of his trials is not logical reason but the depth of existential feeling. Without understanding that the book of Ecclesiastes wrestles on the existential plane, one cannot understand either the problems, or the trials, or the rejection of the trials, or the conclusions and solutions.

If so, from here on the search for wisdom, as a concept within the book, takes on a more precise meaning: this is not a matter of building orderly Platonic or scientific theories, nor of positing a moral ideology, nor of engaging in theology. It is a matter of the quest of existential thought, and therefore the conclusions will deal with the worlds of life, with what occurs "under the sun," with a description of human existence and its challenges.[4]

D. The Failure of Rationality

True, we began from the verse in which Kohelet describes his initial turn to wisdom (1:13), but, in fact, already from the opening section of the book we can learn part of its conclusions. One can sense well the insight that, on the plane of intellect and logical wisdom, we have not found sufficient explanations — mainly regarding the meaning of the small deeds of man and his choices relative to the immense worlds of a fixed, undeveloping and unchanging cosmic cycle and system. As the book advances, we hear more and more disturbing, conceptual-perceptual questions that have no real answer — what is the difference between human existence and the existence of the beast;[5] how are we to understand the existence of the oppressed and of injustice under the sun;[6] what advantage do life's achievements bring if everything, in the end, comes to nothing;[7] the question of the righteous man to whom evil happens and the wicked man to whom good happens,[8] and so forth. These questions are formulated at times as wonderment and at times as a statement in a pessimistic, despairing style, and their scattering across the entire book, from its beginning to its end, already teaches us a principled statement about Kohelet's attitude and experience regarding wisdom — to the most essential questions existing within the space of reality, it gives no answer whatsoever. Kohelet arrives at a most profound conclusion, namely, that rational thought does not even have the power to engage with the weighty metaphysical questions whose influence on existence is fateful. In general, Kohelet argues, man has no power to attain any answers at all to questions touching on essence.[9] These matters are beyond him; he lives imprisoned within his limited consciousness, and his spiritual-ideational thought is without any true anchor. Out of the disappointment at the absence of answers to the questions of the meaning and essence of reality, we receive the discouragement and the pessimistic mindset expressed in the book.

Let us digress for a moment from the book's treatment of wisdom, in favor of an important and principled discussion for understanding the book and its style.

One could object and argue that Kohelet's preoccupation and concern with the questions above[10] constitutes a difficulty for what we assumed earlier. We argued that the focus of the search for wisdom in the book is an answer to questions that are not metaphysical but existential, almost pragmatic. From this claim one could infer that Kohelet contains no engagement at all with metaphysical questions of the kind we listed above. An existentialist philosopher is not supposed, seemingly, to take interest in questions like that of divine justice in the world, or the question of choice versus cosmic determinism. We are accustomed to understanding existentialist philosophy as dealing only with man's narrow, immediate concerns and his ways of living, with everything beyond that being, as it were, nothing to it.

This understanding is correct when we deal with existentialist philosophy in an analytical manner, relating to it as an abstract spiritual discipline. Kohelet, by contrast, does not come to lecture us on the doctrine of existentialism. Kohelet expresses, in a unique style, a kind of diary-monologue of the murmuring of his inner soul, with all its struggles, experiences,

sufferings, wonderings, beliefs, doubts and conclusions. This is a book that brings to light the occurrence and ferment within the depths of the believing personality. As a faithful description of a total psychic occurrence, the book does not sketch only the depth-experiences and the emotions, but also the movements of streams of thought, the foundational beliefs, and the conclusions of reflective observation on life. As in the life of the soul, the book sustains a dialectic — between faith and skepticism, between experience and reason, between pessimistic despair and optimistic joy, between the desire for possessions and the desire for wisdom, between contentment of spirit and the sense of existential emptiness. When the book is grasped as an orderly summary of philosophical conclusions, one cannot explain its various contradictions, its lack of continuity, and the sense of dissonance one feels when listening to the various voices arising from within it.

Therefore, the mention of the deep philosophical questions about reality and its meaning, about justice and evil in the world, is understandable and clear despite the book's existential character. For existence itself is deeply bound up with the world of thought, and the questions that trouble the soul are not confined to the domain of the psychic and the pragmatically personal, but touch the whole of being and all the objective phenomena man encounters. Man is a rational creature, and therefore reason is not a system separate from existence but a principal part of existence itself.

E. Joy

After the disappointment with rationality, and the gloomy discovery that pure reason has nothing to offer regarding the great questions of life, Kohelet remains pessimistic and dejected. On the face of it, despair seems unavoidable — we remain without any capacity to decipher the meaning of reality, nor the meaning and purpose of existence.

Except that Kohelet also has a further conclusion — the inability to understand does not mean that we must exist in a feeling of meaninglessness and emptiness. Contrary to the common conception, according to which the one voice that repeats itself systematically in the book of Ecclesiastes is "hevel" (vanity), there is within it another recurring refrain, in an entirely different key — joy in labor. This idea is formulated in various forms throughout the book:

"I know that there is nothing better for them than to rejoice, and to do good in his life. And also that every man should eat and drink, and enjoy the good of all his labor — it is the gift of God." (3:12–13)

"There is nothing better for a man than that he should eat and drink, and make his soul enjoy good in his labor. This also I saw, that it was from the hand of God." (2:24)

"So I saw that there is nothing better than that a man should rejoice in his own works, for that is his portion; for who shall bring him to see what shall be after him?" (3:22)

"Behold that which I have seen: it is good and fitting for one to eat and to drink, and to enjoy the good of all his labor that he takes under the sun, all the days of his life which God gives him, for that is his portion. Every man also to whom God has given riches and

wealth, and has given him power to eat of it, and to take his portion, and to rejoice in his labor — this is the gift of God." (5:17–18)

"So I commended joy, since there is nothing better for a man under the sun than to eat, and to drink, and to be joyful; for that shall accompany him in his labor all the days of his life which God gives him under the sun." (8:15)

If we look closely at these and similar verses, we find that although they may contain a conscious reconciliation with the "vanity" of the world, and although they offer no theoretical-philosophical solution to this problem at all — they raise the possibility of joy nonetheless. In this, Kohelet is, in effect, establishing two things: first, that joy is possible, after all; and second, that it is the correct way to live.

In order to understand and translate into our own world how joy is possible in a world darkened of meaning, we must examine the way we conceive of such "meaning." [11] When what is sought is an idea or ideal external to the very existence of the world, one can arrive at entanglement and despair. But when life itself is the very meaning, when the blood flowing in my veins is itself the sense, is itself the good — the need for a separate system of ideas weakens. When I laugh, love and rejoice, I do not ask "why" and I do not ask "for what purpose" in order to experience a bright and positive experience. The vitality of joy, joy in life itself, are the existential anchor points, are the taste of life. I delight in the fact that I have pleasure, and I attain contentment not from an external source but from my very existence, from the existence of an experience of contentment in life.

If we continue and broaden this conception, we learn that the problem of frustration is not a natural problem, but the result of analytical thinking, which severs our heart from the pulse of its life-filled beats and sends it into an intellectual exile, in which it is supposed to seek a meaning that lies beyond existence, beyond the soul, beyond nature. [12] A person seeking a real and successful solution will seek the meaning of his life within his life, and not outside it. In a religious vocabulary, the fact that God gives us life at every single moment implies that God is present in the very fact of our existence and vitality, and that these are therefore meaningful even on the spiritual plane. [13]

F. "And to Do Good"

Let us return to the book. When Kohelet sketches the optimal activity for man, he repeatedly emphasizes, alongside contentment and joy, labor and deeds. The finest joy, in his view, is a joy that flows from some doing, and it is the very labor and toil coming from that doing that sweeten life and charge joy with some real positive value. It is not entirely clear from the verses what labor exactly is meant, but it seems the reference is, generally, to positive constructive activity — of creation, development and building: whether this is the acquisition and building of fields, servants, pools, orchards and houses, whether it is investment in tilling the soil and agricultural production, whether it is concern for the future of coming generations, or whether it is moral action. What is common to all of these is their virtue of granting the soul true contentment and satisfaction, and the chief fruit of

the undertaking is the very experience of that unique, full, deep, real, meaning-laden joy.
[14]

For Kohelet, it seems, this emphasis matters in order to distinguish the finest joy from dissipation.[15] Dissipation, too, was tried by Kohelet at the start of the book, but his impression of it is negative and dismissive: "I said in my heart, come now, I will test you with mirth, and enjoy pleasure; and behold, this also was vanity. I said of laughter, it is mad, and of mirth, what does it accomplish?" (2:1–2). From the verses that follow, describing a different and further trial, one can better understand what kind of joy is meant here. The following verses describe a trial defined as a middle ground between holding fast to wisdom and holding fast to folly — that is, a life of pleasures and luxuries, but with a settled mind and in measure.[16] From the description of this trial as a different one, arousing renewed hope, we understand that the mirth and dissipation described in verses 1–2 describe an experience of sensory intoxication, "heavy" materialism, an extreme tilt toward the immediate and uncontrolled realization of bodily desire, a kind of ecstasy.

We do not fully know what troubled Kohelet in the experiences of dissipation and controlled hedonism he tried, and what caused him to declare of them that "this too is vanity," to turn against them and to prefer the joy that comes from labor. Why must a person rejoice specifically in some deed, rather than simply rejoicing and delighting in the simple, material pleasures of life? The book leaves us this philosophical gap unanswered, to which we will return further on.[17] In any case, Kohelet's conclusion is that true joy can be produced only by the person who builds his life and directs his deeds in light of some direction or purpose. Dissipation is "empty joy," and it does not fill the psychic need and desire for existential fullness. By contrast, the natural and healthy joy in our labor gives life a sense of satisfaction, when the very labor and work, and the very "doing of good," are accepted as the content of life.[18]

G. The Role of Wisdom

We have dwelt at length on the subject of joy and the meaning of life, in order to understand, from within it, the role Kohelet grants to wisdom. Indeed, we might mistakenly think that, as a result of his disappointment with rationality, and out of his search for joy, Kohelet would turn to a way of life based on drives and natural instincts alone, without restraint or moderation by reason. If uprightness is naturalness and joy in naturalness, and thought is the complication and the source of frustration — the seemingly natural conclusion would be a maximal striving toward unprocessed naturalness, toward a joy attuned only to the inner murmurings of body and soul, and not to any concept or idea existing on a more abstract or higher spiritual-intellectual plane. We will answer this question below.

Against the background of all we have written above in the chapter on joy, we can understand from what vantage point Kohelet saw positive sides in wisdom. One can see that woven through the book's verses is the claim that wisdom has no small value as an aid in life. Kohelet's soul's request, the form of his gaze and his orientation, are pragmatic — a

thing of positive value will, for him, be defined as a thing that brings happiness and a joyful life. Except — and we have already noted this point above — that in rejecting metaphysical ideals and principles as guides for his path, Kohelet does not fall into coarse and base existence, and he is not tempted to throw off all restraints, culture, values, faith and spirituality. Kohelet does not advocate a life of hedonism and bodily wildness. He recognizes that the fitting, proper and happy way of life for man contains spirit as well, and that his soul's quest is composed not only of domains of "dust from the earth" but also of domains of "the image of God."

If so, Kohelet argues that although wisdom is not an end in itself, and although it is limited in the content with which it can assist man, it is nonetheless among the important and positive tools given to man in order to live his life better. Wisdom, like all the powers of the soul, has the role of assisting and contributing its share to the task of life — joy in labor, which grants sense. With the aid of reason, man will be more effective, will draw conclusions about what is correct, beautiful, delightful and beneficial, and will live his life with joy.

From here it is understood that the reference is to the wisdom of living, one that assists man in achieving his goals. The achievement of goals need not be ambitious or achievement-oriented in a narrow sense, and wisdom does not contribute only to the development of technology and the conquest of utilitarian ends. The advantages of wisdom are described in the verses not only as being "better than weapons of war" but also as "excelling darkness as light excels it." In these and other verses, the reference is to a deep wisdom of living, an existential wisdom. Despite its limitations, by the power of reason man comes to know himself, his wills, the inner tensions planted within his nature, the deep strata of his soul. He learns from experience, and, together with analytical breakdown and abstraction, he draws existential and ontological conclusions about himself — what brings him deep joy, how to distinguish dissipation from joy, what advantage lies in each deed he does and each trait he adopts, what the source of his feelings is and what the essence of his experiences is. The strongest proof for the claim that this is the wisdom spoken of favorably in the book is the fact that the book itself is a long thought-process, analyzing the various components of human existence and determining their value, their advantage and disadvantage, their vitality or negativity.

Wisdom is vital for man in order to order his powers and his life. Kohelet is not impressed by a life of outburst and of a simple, unweighed flow of forces; he proposes abandoning metaphysics, but not reflection and intellectual settledness. The purpose of reflection is to find ways to a full and good life, replete with contentment and joy. The object of reflection is human experience — not with a shallow gaze but a deep one; not with rashness but with settled judgment and accumulated experience; not in external philosophical categories but in tense inner listening. Only by attending to the questions of life, and by examining the winding paths of existence, do we arrive at the life we seek.

It is possible that this way of thinking seems strange to us. The main cause of this feeling is our habit of identifying the pragmatic-existential way of thinking with hedonism and

materialism. We were raised on a religious worldview that anchors obligations and restraints in a transcendent being, and thus an impression formed within us that if this transcendent being — God, absolute truth and reward — did not exist, our lives would lack spiritual restraint and obligation as well. In light of Freud's concepts, the social "superego," which restrains the animal drives of the "id," is a product of culture. Culture contradicts human nature only because it weighs the necessary public order, in contrast to the anarchistic nature of the "id." Out of our emphasis on the revelatory, "legal" and rigid dimension of the word of God, we have, in effect, unconsciously leaned toward the psychological theory represented by Freud.

However, one can explain the gap between the demands of the "id" and the "superego" differently, in a manner grounded in psychological teachings other than Freud's,[19] and argue that there are different strata within the "id" itself: just as there is an instinctive drive for life and for sex, so too there is a transcendence (chereg) toward encounter with the transcendent, and a longing for spiritual meaning. The more spiritual and refined drives find greater expression in social culture (which creates the "superego") precisely because of their closeness to the rational and communicative side of man. In this way we avoid having to resort to the forced argument, in my opinion, that culture — which is entirely the product of humanity's own hands — is based mostly on technical constraints and expresses no essences at all that are immanent to man. The existence of boredom, for example, attests to a psychic transcendence toward some superiority. Kohelet's trials reveal that the human soul is far too broad to be satisfied with coarse materiality, and that its spiritual sides seek a depth and reality higher than mere amusement. At the foundation of Kohelet's worldview lies a definition of man as a creature composed of spirit as well,[20] and therefore he does not need to compensate us with an explanation of his implicit beliefs regarding what is naturally fitting and upright for man[21] — fear of God, morality, doing good, gravity of spirit regarding life, contentment with little, and so on. From his perspective, these beliefs are natural and normal, self-evident from life itself, and require no philosophical or metaphysical anchor. We too, trained in metaphysical and theological conceptions within the framework of our faith, identify with these psychological-ontological conceptions: we believe that within human nature there is a "good inclination," that there is a pure divine soul, and that there is a correspondence between one's soul and the Torah and morality.

H. The Drawbacks of Wisdom[22]

A further voice regarding wisdom, arising from the verses, moves in a direction opposite to the last attitude we surveyed. Against the role Kohelet grants wisdom, and his trust in this tool as assisting and contributing to the attainment of happiness and joy, Kohelet actually emphasizes the pragmatic drawbacks, on the path to happiness, of excessive wisdom. This finds expression mainly in the following verses:

"I spoke with my own heart, saying, Behold, I have attained great wisdom, more than all who were before me over Jerusalem; and my heart has had great experience of wisdom and knowledge. And I applied my heart to know wisdom, and to know madness and folly;

I perceived that this also was a striving after wind. For in much wisdom is much vexation, and he that increases knowledge increases sorrow." (1:16–18)

Kohelet tells us, from his personal experience but as a general conclusion, that the increase of wisdom brings hard existential suffering. This experience can be understood from several different directions. The first direction, which seems to be the one embedded in the plain sense of the text, is that this concerns the frustration arising from the absence of answers to the questions that arise within us. Wisdom drives us to ask and take interest in questions that have no answer, and it brings our soul into a state of distress, doubt and emptiness as long as no well-founded, satisfying solution is found. It hungers after domains beyond its reach, and thus leaves us in torment of soul. It finds it hard to understand and to accept, with reconciliation, its own limitedness, and so it does not let go. Kohelet warns us that if we devote ourselves to the philosophical mindset, the inquirer who always searches for a logical explanation for what occurs, we will pay a heavy price of frustration and pain in places where such an explanation apparently does not exist (at least not by human categories of thought). The more we make use of wisdom, the more dominant and active it will become in our lives, and thus it will bring suffering upon us at the very edge of the limit of comprehension and meaning.

A different direction comes from an awareness of the general price of excessive learning and consciousness. Contrary to his early assumption at the start of the book, Kohelet discovers that perhaps it is not correct to ask the questions at all. If we use the terms of Rabbi Nachman,[23] perhaps the "innocent" position, one that focuses on the momentary emotional experience and pushes the rational tendency out of the center of existence, precisely in its simplicity leads to a happier life than the "wise" position. Intellectualism only delays man from the natural, flowing normalcy, and thereby distances him from natural joy and vitality. It adds a dimension of heaviness, whereas happiness may perhaps be found in a lighter, more simple, more relaxed way of life.

The price of excessive awareness lies not only in existential heaviness and complexity, but also in the pessimistic influence of knowledge. Learning and inquiry bring man to a recognition of tragic or incomprehensible sides present in human occurrence. In an "innocent" life, a person is not obligated to encounter these phenomena, and he can also choose to avert his eyes from them. By contrast, the person who chooses to know and to learn goes outside his own narrow domain and surveys social or universal-human phenomena. This opening-up also confronts him with phenomena of wickedness and distortion, and opens his eyes to know the absurdity present in reality. These insights seep, against his will, into his emotional experience of existence, and even when he chooses to divert his gaze and his aim toward the natural joy of life, that joy will not have the same force and simplicity. The same holds for existential wisdom itself — it can bring man precisely to inner entanglement, to a recognition of the dialectic embedded within him, which will lead to its emotional internalization. Reflection may sharpen and clarify the complexity present within us, and thereby dim the total emotional experiences and cloud the purity of the simple general emotional state.

I. Summary

In order to present a full picture, we must examine and summarize the sum of the attitudes found in the book toward wisdom, and strive to unpack the complexity present within it. It seems that, in general, if we look closely, there are four layers of attitude toward wisdom in the verses, built one upon the other.

The first attitude, expressed in the first trial (end of chapter 1), is the rejection of the process of gaining wisdom as a solution to the distress of the meaning of life. The experience of intellectual development and general philosophical inquiry do not satisfy the soul: first, because it is unclear what their purpose is, and at times the pursuit of knowledge feels like an act empty of direction and of destined content. Beyond this, they do not satisfy because they do not settle the question of man's eternity. Man seeks to touch eternity; he seeks that his words, his sons who walk in his ways, and his undertakings, express his anchor in eternity; but, sadly, none of these truly touch eternity — everything can, in retrospect, turn out to have been useless. Wisdom and learning do not solve these problems, and do not immunize man against arbitrary death. In sum, wisdom cannot constitute a sufficient direction for the sake of which to live one's life.

The second attitude is the recognition of the limits of reason, and of the shortness of understanding and the paucity of man's true capacity for comprehension. Even if we do not judge the purpose for which we gain wisdom, and neutralize the question of why one should strive to inquire in wisdom and logic, in intellectualism and philosophy — this central problem of the shortness of the capacity for attainment will still stand. The questions we ask — about the essence of the world and its purpose, about divine justice in the world, about the meaning of man and the meaning of life — are questions lying beyond the domain of human reason. "I said, I will be wise; but it was far from me." Kohelet stresses that this attempt is futile and doomed to failure, and thereby defines well for us the fitting bounds of the attempt to use the power of reason.

The third attitude is the view of wisdom as a positive aid. The wise man will have an advantage in many domains of life; he will be more effective and will achieve more of his aspirations. In more psychic domains, existential wisdom helps man reach the happiness he longs for. Through knowing himself, through analyzing the psychic factors that influence and contribute to him, through examining and inquiring into the foundations of his existence, his loves and his tendencies — man will arrive at a considered and fitting way of life, in which he can extract the most from his life.

The fourth attitude is opposite and contrary to the third, and it expresses regret over the entire process of gaining wisdom. Kohelet explains to us that wisdom carries a heavy existential price, and it is not certain that its advantage over darkness is greater than the pain it brings in its wings. Wisdom is, in many cases, oppressive: both because it can bring frustration and despair in its engagement with a meaningless world; because it subjects the powers of natural, flowing life to the rational dictate; and because it confronts man with

worlds of pain, evil and injustice, and opens him to them — worlds that were not part of his world before he came to know them by way of gaining wisdom.

We are thus left with a complicated, even contradictory, attitude toward wisdom, which can explain to us the source of the contradictions we pointed to in the plain sense of the text. Part of the contradictions arise from a relation to a different kind of wisdom — the theoretical-metaphysical and the existential; another part arises from a relation to different functions of wisdom, and to places where the attitude depends on the correct use that can be made of this power; and yet another part expresses a genuine ambivalence regarding the entire process of learning and reflection. Kohelet, it seems, does not settle on an absolute relation between the third and fourth attitudes we examined above, and remains in a deep dialectic regarding the choice between them. On the one hand, he feels that the right thing to do is to observe, examine, think and analyze the various states of life and draw their lessons. One who does not do so seems, in his eyes, to walk in darkness, while wisdom illuminates the paths of the world and guides the wise man toward the light and pleasantness found within them. On the other hand, at times his feeling is one of sorrow and regret over his entry into the world of gaining wisdom. The information, or the complex analytical conclusions of experience, weigh upon him, and he becomes convinced that he would have been better off without this burden.

Will Kohelet, in the end, agree with a model of life of the "simple one," like the one presented in Rabbi Nachman's tale? Would he choose, had he the ability to turn back time, to repeat "I applied my heart to seek and to search out by wisdom concerning all that is done under the sun," or, rather, to change course and suppress this engagement? Did he regret his quest "to find delightful words, and that which was written uprightly, words of truth"?

I think it is hard to find a solution to this question, and it seems that Kohelet himself could not give a fixed and decisive answer. One can learn of the persistence of this deliberation also from the book's closing. On the one hand, we find that the book is summed up with the statement that "besides being wise, Kohelet also taught the people knowledge; yes, he pondered, and sought out, and set in order many proverbs" (12:9); that is, that the fact that he gained wisdom and inquired had a blessed influence and a positive fruit. We also learn that this was indeed his quest, to find delightful words, and it seems that he indeed attained this, and taught us "words of the wise." On the other hand, after a book full of reflections, wonderings, thoughts and inquiries, he ends on a cautious and warning note: "And furthermore, my son, be warned: of making many books there is no end, and much study is a weariness of the flesh" (12:12). As though saying, from his own experience, that although this engagement has meaning, has importance, and also has fruit — one should not overdo it. It is possible that he found that his conclusions, laid before us in this book, analyze and exhaust the discussion to the finest degree, and that there is no need to go through the discouragement and the toil in order to arrive at those same true conclusions. It seems that the discussion and the deliberation over the question of wisdom were never sealed; they

accompany us in the closing notes of the book, and remain to echo in our thoughts in its wake.

It remains only for us to be blessed by his deepest insights, which he left us in this book, and to steer our course by the light of its brief verses, which are an instance of "a little that holds much."

J. Closing: Kohelet and Postmodernism

The book of Ecclesiastes contains deliberations, claims, conclusions and experiences of a special kind, strange and foreign relative to the accepted religious landscape. It sounds as though it expresses states of mind that are essentially opposed to our spiritual world (or, at the very least, far from it): pessimism, determinism, hedonism, skepticism, anti-rationalism, and so on. Beyond this, for nearly every question Kohelet asks, we hold different answers from his, so deeply instilled in us that we do not understand why he does not offer them in the plain sense of the text. The question of justice in the world troubles us less because of the existence of the World to Come; the skeptical mindset is regarded by us as a kind of "Amalek," because of our deep attachment to a life of faith and trust; pessimism is rejected in favor of the optimistic faith in divine providence and redemption; the question of existential emptiness has no place for us, owing to our upbringing to accept Torah and the service of God as the purpose of man and the world; the question of the essential difference between the spirit of man and the spirit of the beast is clear to us from the conception of the image of God, and we do not understand at all why death should undermine anchors of faith of this kind; and so forth.

Because of this it is hard for us to study Kohelet at all, and harder still to study it in a way that strives for the plain sense of the text, and harder still to draw from it a source of real faith-based, religious guidance. It seems, at times, that the deliberation of the Sages regarding the book's inclusion among the sacred writings[24] has not fully healed even to this day, despite having been decided in halakha and in practice.[25]

In our times, new winds are blowing in the world. These shifts find expression in every possible domain — philosophy, phenomenology, art, politics, feminism, psychology and sociology, coupledness, and even physics. These deep shifts across all the spaces of human existence have been characterized by many as a new age — the postmodern age.[26]

We, as those who keep faith with Torah and tradition, are not occupied with adopting every new wind that blows in the world. Our response to historical shifts, to a new philosophical language, to contemporary states of mind and to the changing of generations, is wary, cautious, measured and slow. Nevertheless, in the end, the sages of the generation do grapple with the winds of the times: some by raising walls and fortifying Judaism against them, some by attack and defense, some by translating the faith-religious language into the language of the generation, some by adopting part of the true ideas present within them and including them within the world of faith, and some by striving for an Orthodox synthesis between the worlds. It seems that the way of coping characterized by cautious attentiveness

to what occurs outside, and taking responsibility to renew the faith through Torah study and its deepened clarification in light of "the nature of the time," is the way that characterizes us as sons of "Religious Zionism," and as students of figures like Rav Kook and Rav Soloveitchik, of blessed memory.

One of the important means we use in order to find, within the Torah, a way of coping with and connecting to new ideas, is the renewal of sources of study. Every generation has a different channel of nourishment from the eternal wellspring of the Torah. Even in generations replete with broad and extensive Torah study, there are sources that constitute a formative factor in the religious worldview, whose study is fruitful and creative, and there are those that do not serve as a cornerstone of the worldview, but rather as ornament or a side layer. Whether consciously or unconsciously, religious society, in grappling with general outlooks, chooses for itself new traditional sources that will constitute a central spiritual anchor fitting for the world of faith it wishes to build.

For example, in order to grapple with Zionism and to contain it within religiosity, the study of the Bible, and especially the books of the Former Prophets, was renewed on an immense scale, and engagement with it became more intensive and of higher quality; in parallel to the spread of the New Age movement, new study halls arose placing the teaching of the mystical tradition at their center; out of an encounter with the doctrines of existentialism, Rav Soloveitchik placed the study of the book of Genesis as a constitutive component within his teaching;^[27] and so forth.

Most of us do not experience postmodernism in any significant way, and remain behind, with the wondrous teachings of those who grappled with modernity. But those of us who come into greater contact with the secular-Israeli world feel, more and more, that the accepted religious language, even that of Religious Zionism, can no longer speak to most of the secular. Many central components of the religious-national worldview are distant from their world, both philosophically and existentially: nationalism, deterministic optimism, reliance on and engagement with ideas and metaphysics, complete confidence in the righteousness of the path, dogmatism, the myth of human power and capacity, romanticism, a conception of man's purpose as belonging only to the collective, and so on. By contrast, the postmodern experience is composed of entirely different concepts: loneliness, individualism, despair, multiculturalism, doubt, freedom, emptiness, creativity and authenticity, pragmatism, faith in the concrete alone (or in mysticism), and so on.

The need slowly awakens to find a facet of connection to the Torah and to faith also from within a postmodern world. Of course, this does not mean a total adoption of this world's starting assumptions, nor even the creation of a synthesis between it and faith. We will not rush to accept into ourselves external ideas and outlooks merely out of a wish to build a bridge between the Torah and reality. The process is different — out of our cautious contact with the general periphery beyond our closed, believing space of existence, we receive influence indirectly, we clarify it and incorporate it carefully, purified of its dross, and we discover new layers out of our sincere encounter with the Torah, lights hidden within the Torah itself.

My contribution to the discussion is to propose the book of Ecclesiastes as a solution to this need. It seems to me that if we examine the book of Ecclesiastes, even merely the subjects that occupy it and the existential language spoken within it, we can come away with the impression that it can serve as an address for the believing person who encounters a postmodern world, when this meeting of worlds produces a deep need for a renewed reading and study of the eternal sources of the Torah. In-depth study of the book leads us to engage with issues touching the very navel of this experience — the question of the nagging doubt, coping with it and living in its shadow; the question of despair at the world, out of a great awareness of the evil within it; the question of the search for content and meaning, and the attempt to find them under the heavens; the question of learning and wisdom, which we have dealt with somewhat in this essay; various questions of the search for existential happiness, such as the place of joy and dissipation as against seriousness and depth, or the distinction between healthy naturalness and harmful addiction to material things; and so forth.

We hold many reservations about what emerges from the book (in its plain sense), and I am not sure that even when we arrive at a coherent, good and well-grounded interpretation for this wondrous and difficult book, we will be obligated to accept its philosophical and religious conclusions.[28] However, the study of a book dealing with these subjects, through a lens that is undoubtedly one of holiness — even if we leave the discussion on a theoretical, non-binding level alone — will certainly have a real influence on our world and on our faith, and perhaps precisely through this engagement we will merit to be renewed, refined, clarified, and to raise the horn of faith, and to be blessed also by the unique illumination of this time, for the sake of enriching our Torah world, "that the Torah be made great and glorious."

* * *

Notes

1. Rav Yehuda, son of Rav Shmuel bar Shilat, said in the name of Rav: the Sages sought to suppress the book of Ecclesiastes, because its words contradict one another (Shabbat 30b).
2. A highly significant part of understanding the foundational issue of the book of Ecclesiastes is the interpretation of the key word "hevel." The Ramban, in his homily on Ecclesiastes, explains that the root of the term comes from the breath of the mouth, and that its meaning is a thing that has no lasting existence, that changes, is exchanged, and loses its form and matter in the blink of an eye. In the introduction to Da'at Mikra on Ecclesiastes it is noted that the name "hevel" carries many meanings: "fleeting and perishing, false and empty, of no avail, a thing without substance, senseless and foolish, darkness and gloom, disappointment and pain, an incomprehensible thing — not grasped by the intellect." It seems to us that in Ecclesiastes the word generally describes insignificance, meaninglessness, an emptiness of real or positive content and essence.
3. "So I hated all my labor which I had taken under the sun, seeing that I must leave it to the man who shall be after me. And who knows whether he shall be a wise man or a fool? Yet he shall have rule over all my labor in which I labored, and in which I showed wisdom under the sun. This also is vanity." (2:18–19) Against the background of the life story of King Solomon, to whom the book is attributed, this distress is doubly painful. Solomon's life's work was the military, political and

economic empowerment of the kingdom of Israel; and this followed the life's work of his father, King David, which focused on creating a pan-Israelite consensus around his kingship. During the reign of Rehoboam, Solomon's son, the kingdom split into two, and from there began a process of decline for both. It appears that Solomon was aware of his son's insufficient talent, and, as a result, the question of the meaning of deeds occurred to him with full force; or, alternatively, that the book was written after the prophecy he received regarding the tearing of his kingdom after his days (see 1 Kings 11:11–13).

4. This delimitation will be somewhat qualified in the next section; see below.

5. "For that which befalls the sons of men befalls beasts; even one thing befalls them: as the one dies, so dies the other; yes, they have all one breath, so that man has no preeminence above a beast: for all is vanity." (3:19)

6. "So I returned, and considered all the oppressions that are done under the sun: and behold the tears of such as were oppressed, and they had no comforter; and on the side of their oppressors there was power, but they had no comforter." (4:1)

7. "And this also is a grievous evil, that in all points as he came, so shall he go: and what profit has he who has labored for the wind?" (5:15)

8. "There is a vanity which is done upon the earth: that there are righteous men to whom it happens according to the work of the wicked; again, there are wicked men to whom it happens according to the work of the righteous. I said that this also is vanity." (8:14)

9. See: "For man cannot find out the work that is done under the sun; because though a man labor to seek it out, yet he shall not find it; yes further, though a wise man think to know it, yet shall he not be able to find it." (8:17) In Rav Michael Avraham's book *Two Chariots and a Hot-Air Balloon*, a similar conclusion is formulated as "the emptiness of the analytic"; see there, in the first gate, especially pp. 44–48 (old edition). The matter also recalls the conclusion of the Ran in his homilies (Homily 1) on the subject of the account of creation. The Ran states that, unlike physics — which describes the actions and "occurrences" of objects and the laws of nature, without understanding the reason for things — the account of creation is knowledge of the essence and being of things, and therefore knowledge of the account of creation cannot be attained by reason alone, without the holy spirit.

10. See notes 5–8 above and the text they annotate.

11. This point was sharpened for me by Elyasaf Sternberg, and my thanks are due to him for it.

12. See: "Behold, this alone I have found, that God made man upright; but they have sought out many schemes." (7:29) Man's natural uprightness was meant to bring about natural happiness and joy, but intellectualist thinking undermined this natural-harmonious state and entangled man in many schemes.

13. This is a matter of an existential and conscious transformation — man must feed his sense of meaning from the very fact of existence and life. Life is a positive and valuable thing not because of its clinging to some Platonic world of values separate from it, but simply because it is what it is. Of course, we remain utterly unprotected from the (existential) question of why to define life as positive, or: whence shall inspiration be found to rejoice rather than to be depressed. In certain psychic states the statement "alive = positive" is an axiom of real absoluteness, and in other psychic states (usually those we define as depressive illness or melancholy) this is cast into doubt, or even exchanged for a hatred of life and of one's fellow creatures. This is apparently the dialectical psychic process underlying the book of Ecclesiastes. Perhaps this is the point of choice — to choose to believe that good exists, to succeed in awakening the constructive, positive, beautiful and high forces within the soul. "Therefore choose life." Perhaps, too, this is a dialectic built into the soul — times of an existence of redemption, when life shines from within itself, and

times of an existence in "exile," in which life does not shine of itself and we lean it upon an external purpose, such as serving God out of fear of punishment or expectation of the World to Come.

14. Compare the words of Rabbi Yaakov: "Better one hour of repentance and good deeds in this world than all the life of the World to Come" (Mishnah, Avot 4:17).

15. Joy, too, is among those subjects toward which the book's attitude is not coherent. The simple exegetical solution, adopted also by our Sages, is the distinction between kinds of joy differing in their essence, and we dwell briefly on this division. We should stress that even what we here call "dissipation" is referred to in the book by the name joy, though this is almost purely a sharing of the name alone, while, in fact, the concepts are essentially far apart.

16. "I searched in my heart how to cheer my flesh with wine, my heart yet guiding me with wisdom, and how to lay hold on folly, till I might see what was good for the sons of men, which they should do under heaven all the days of their lives. I made my works great; I built houses, I planted vineyards for myself; I made gardens and orchards for myself, and planted trees in them of every kind of fruit; I made pools of water for myself, to water the forest of growing trees; I acquired servants and maidens, and had servants born in my house; also I had great possessions of herds and flocks, above all who were before me in Jerusalem; I gathered for myself also silver and gold, and the treasure of kings and of the provinces; I got for myself male and female singers, and the delights of the sons of men, various instruments, and that of all kinds. So I became great, and increased more than all who were before me in Jerusalem; also my wisdom remained with me. And whatever my eyes desired, I did not keep from them; I did not withhold my heart from any joy, for my heart rejoiced in all my labor; and this was my portion from all my labor." (2:3–10)

17. As I wrote above, the book was written in an existential style and orientation. Hence it seems that adherence to logical coherence was not its concern, and where we find an inconsistency or some gap in the sequence of arguments, this in no way detracts from the book as a human work written with divine inspiration. The book rests on many prior assumptions it did not trouble to spell out and present. This does not detract from its logic, since it sees itself mainly as analyzing existential experiences and not as responsible for explaining them. It seems that Kohelet relates in a similar way to the fear of God — he does not justify it and does not prove its obligation even in a single place. This fact might seem strange relative to the rest of the book, which stands out precisely for its skepticism; but, in truth, Kohelet is not afraid of axioms, and on the point of the fear of God (not to mention the existence of God) he did not think to cast doubt at all. The fear of God is, for Kohelet, a self-evident act, a matter that is certain and solid in itself. Man is, by his nature, a servant of God.

18. In these words also lies the solution to the distress arising from the possibility that man's labor will come to nothing (see note 3). The actual results of deeds do not darken their meaning; rather, their meaning lies in the fact that they filled life with content and reality. Joy is possible despite the vanity of deeds, if one internalizes the recognition that what matters about them is not their existence in the objective world as such.

19. Such as, for example, the teaching of Viktor Frankl, "logotherapy." See, for example, the second part of his book *Man's Search for Meaning*, and his writings in general.

20. This dualistic conception of man, as composed of body and spirit, is already rooted in the accounts of creation in the Written Torah, but it finds special expression in the book of Ecclesiastes, in its engagement with the soul and spirit of man as components within the whole called man. Although Scripture, in general, does not emphasize this duality, and certainly does not turn it into a dichotomy, it was nonetheless important for us to emphasize it here for the purpose at hand.

21. This is in addition to Kohelet's general habit of not justifying or even explaining his foundational assumptions. See above, note 16.

22. It is possible that in this chapter, in which we explain the drawbacks of wisdom and knowledge, we are touching on the matter of the Tree of Knowledge. The Rambam, in the Guide of the Perplexed (part 1, ch. 2), grapples with the question of how it could be that the sin of the first man earned him knowledge, which is a merit and not a punishment. The Rambam resolves the question by distinguishing between the intellect, which is the image of God, and "knowledge of good and evil," which is "the apprehension of generally accepted opinions" — that is, a mixing of pure intellect with imagination. However, one must grapple with the plain sense of the verses, which teach that the natural result of eating from the Tree of Knowledge was "and your eyes shall be opened, and you shall be as gods, knowing good and evil" — especially if we accept the Rambam's (plausible) assumption that it would not make sense for the result of the sin to be an upgrade and a positive addition to human nature. These matters require a discussion of the power of knowledge and its merit, and a deep inquiry into the matter of the sin of the Tree of Knowledge in general. I hope to deal with this subject in the future, God willing.

23. See Sipurei Ma'asiyot, "The Tale of the Sage and the Simpleton" (Ma'aseh be-Chakham u-be-Tam). It appears that these verses constitute one of the main, if not the sole, Torah sources for this tale.

24. Mishnah, Yadayim 3:5: "All the Holy Scriptures render the hands unclean. The Song of Songs and Ecclesiastes render the hands unclean. Rabbi Yehudah says: the Song of Songs renders the hands unclean, but there is a dispute regarding Ecclesiastes. Rabbi Yossi says: Ecclesiastes does not render the hands unclean, but there is a dispute regarding the Song of Songs. Rabbi Shimon says: Ecclesiastes is among the leniencies of Beit Shammai and the stringencies of Beit Hillel. Rabbi Shimon ben Azzai said: I have a tradition from the mouth of seventy-two elders, on the day they seated Rabbi Elazar ben Azaryah in the [Sages'] session, that the Song of Songs and Ecclesiastes render the hands unclean. Rabbi Akiva said... they disputed only concerning Ecclesiastes. Rabbi Yochanan ben Yehoshua, the son of the father-in-law of Rabbi Akiva, said: it was in accordance with the words of ben Azzai that they disputed, and so they concluded."

25. My sense is that even one who engages with, teaches and writes about the book does not strive for its plain sense, owing to an unreadiness to accept the implications of the book as it is. This is legitimate, mainly because it seems that our Sages, too, did this in relating to various verses in the book, though this claim requires deeper examination. In any case, what emerges is that it is hard for all of us to accept that Ecclesiastes, in its plain sense, can constitute a true world of faith and religion, and it is possible that this difficulty requires us to examine our own religious worldview.

26. Since a great deal has already been written to summarize and briefly survey the main points of this new consciousness, I see no point in detailing and proving the matter here. These words are based on descriptions and definitions I have heard and read in various places dealing with the "postmodern condition," and mainly on the analysis in the book *The Bowed Rebellion* [Ha-Mered Ha-Shafuf], and that in the closing chapter of Acharekha Narutza (mainly pp. 485–493).

27. See on this the essay of my teacher, Rav Yuval Sherlo, "The Weight of the Chapters of Creation in the Teaching of Rav Soloveitchik and Its Significance," in: *Pituchei Chotam II*, a collection of essays of Yeshivat Hesder Petach Tikva, 5766.

28. See above, note 25.